

CASE ID: 197807710816

EPISODE NAME: Sino-Vietnamese Split

1978/07/03 - 1988/11

Sender: China (710)

Target: Vietnam (816)

Issue: Retaliate for Alliance or Alignment Choice (7)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 1978/07/03, China officially cut off aid and withdrew its technical advisors from Vietnam.¹ The decision reflected a host of disputes between the two nations, including Vietnam's treatment of its ethnically Chinese minority and the country's alignment with the Soviet Union.² Relations were mostly normalized in 1988/11 when Vietnam issued Directive No. 118, resuming some imports from China.³

Narrative:

On 1978/07/03, China officially cut off aid and withdrew its technical advisors from Vietnam.⁴ Prior to 1978, China had supplied military and economic aid as Vietnam battled its southern counterpart in the Vietnam War. Between 1965-1975, China supplied Vietnam economic aid worth 11.2 billion yuan.⁵ However, this aid dropped considerably after 1975, highlighted by Vietnam's imports of Chinese raw imports declining from 750 million yuan in 1975 to 43 million yuan in 1977.⁶

This breakdown in economic ties was a symptom of a growing rift between Vietnam and China, as Vietnam was against the Chinese-backed Khmer Rouge in Cambodia while China was critical of Vietnam's treatment of ethnic Han.⁷ Moreover, the Sino-Soviet split had intensified pressure on Vietnam to enter into Moscow or Beijing's orbit.⁸

¹ "Peking Ends All Aid to the Vietnamese, Recalling Advisors," *New York Times*, July 4th, 1978.
<https://www.nytimes.com/1978/07/04/archives/peking-ends-all-aid-to-the-vietnamese-recalling-advisers-chinese.html>.

² Path, Kosal. "China's Economic Sanctions against Vietnam, 1975-1978," *The China Quarterly*, no. 212 (2012): p. 1048-1049, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23509480>.

³ "China and Vietnam Normalize Relations," *Washington Post*, November 6th, 1991.
<https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/politics/1991/11/06/china-and-vietnam-normalize-relations/8b90e568-cb51-44a3-9a84-90a515e29129/>.

⁴ "Peking Ends All Aid to the Vietnamese, Recalling Advisors," *New York Times*, July 4th, 1978.
<https://www.nytimes.com/1978/07/04/archives/peking-ends-all-aid-to-the-vietnamese-recalling-advisers-chinese.html>.

⁵ Kosal Path, "China's Economic Sanctions against Vietnam, 1975-1978," *The China Quarterly*, no. 212 (2012): p. 1048-1049. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23509480>.

⁶ Ibid, p. 1049.

⁷ Ibid, p. 1050.

⁸ Ibid, p. 1049..

Throughout 1977 and 1978, reductions in Chinese aid to Vietnam were used as leverage to pressure Vietnam into lessening its assimilation policies of its Han minority. Vietnam refused to budge, which culminated with Chinese vessels arriving at Hai Phong on 1977/05/26 and Ho Chi Minh City on 1977/06/09 to repatriate ethnic Han back to China.⁹ Feeling the economic pressure of Chinese aid reductions, Vietnam joined the USSR-backed COMECON on 1978/06/29.¹⁰ In response to this, China withdrew all of its remaining aid and technical advisors on 1978/07/03.¹¹ There are no records of Vietnam distancing itself from the USSR or improving its treatment of the Han following China's aid revocation.

Despite the continuing gulf between China and Vietnam, the two nations would resume trading with one another in 1988/11 when Vietnam issued Directive No. 118.¹² Three years later, a full diplomatic normalization would occur on 1991/11/05.¹³

⁹ Ibid, 1055.

¹⁰ "Vietnam Joins Comecon," *New York Times*, June 30th, 1978.

<https://www.nytimes.com/1978/06/30/archives/vietnam-joins-comecon.html>.

¹¹ "Peking Ends All Aid to the Vietnamese, Recalling Advisors," *New York Times*, July 4th, 1978.

<https://www.nytimes.com/1978/07/04/archives/peking-ends-all-aid-to-the-vietnamese-recalling-advisers-chinese.html>.

¹² Brantly Womack, "Sino-Vietnamese Border Trade: The Edge of Normalization," *Asian Survey*, Vol. 34 No. 6 (June 1994): p. 499, <https://www.jstor-org.www2.lib.ku.edu/stable/pdf/2645337.pdf>.

¹³ "China and Vietnam Normalize Relations," *Washington Post*, November 6th, 1991.

<https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/politics/1991/11/06/china-and-vietnam-normalize-relations/8b90e568-cb51-44a3-9a84-90a515e29129/>.